

Efforts at noise abatement proved equally futile. The “walls” of the enclosure were wrapped in thick industrial carpeting to muffle the ungodly combination of noises that emerged from there. On top of the roaring of three hundred or so maniacal traders, there was the noise of the beeping monitors, the overhead public-address system, and thirty phones incessantly ringing off the hook. All at once.

Even before the opening bell, well in advance of trading, the players would jockey for position in the pit so as to be the first to be recognized by the specialists, standing slightly above them on the podium overlooking the floor of the pit.

The best way for X to get a front-row position was to finagle Y out of the pit. This was often accomplished by the simple expedient of arranging for Y to be paged out front—usually by X’s clerk standing two feet away, using a wall phone. The minute Y left, X would slip into the vacated spot and stay there, not budging an inch. By the time an infuriated Y returned to the pit, he would find it impossible to worm his way back in.

Given that sort of competitive environment, mistakes were bound to occur that could test the best of friendships.

One particularly active day, my clerk jotted down that I had bought “*fifteen* options contracts at the price of thirteen and a half,” while the opposing trader yelled back that he’d sold me “*fifty* contracts at thirteen and a half.”

The difference between saying fifteen and hearing fifty led to a \$47,250 misunderstanding that had to come out of one of our pockets the following day. What made it particularly awkward was that the aggrieved trader was a rather good-looking guy I’d had a date with the evening before, one of those rare occasions when my restricted life-style allowed me a night out. Because the transaction reporter standing next to me during the trade also swore to having heard me say “fifteen,” my opponent had a tough time proving the error to be mine.

Either of us could have sought a ruling by a floor referee or gone to formal arbitration, which would have put a crimp